The Hindu
EDITORIAL ANALYSIS

25th January 2025

PREPARE FOR BANK (PO/ CLERK), SSC,UPSC, State PSC, CAT,CTET,RAILWAY EXAMS,CDS, TET, NDA/AIRFORCE, NET and all Govt. Exams

VOCABULARY

1. Antiquity (प्राचीनता)

Meaning: The ancient past, especially the period before the Middle Ages.
Synonyms: Ancientness, archaicness, oldness
Antonyms: Modernity, newness, novelty
Example: The relics found during the excavation are proof of the site's antiquity.

2. Deciphering (व्याख्या करना)

Meaning: Converting a text or code into normal language; understanding something complex.
Synonyms: Interpreting, decoding, solving
Antonyms: Obscuring, encrypting, complicating
Example: The team is working on deciphering the ancient script discovered in the ruins.

VOCABULARY

3. Derail (बाधा पहुंचाना)

Meaning: To cause something (like a train or a plan) to go off track or fail.
Synonyms: Disrupt, hinder, thwart
Antonyms: Support, advance, facilitate
Example: The sudden economic crisis derailed the company's expansion plans.

4. Fray (तनाव, झगड़ा)

Meaning: A situation of intense activity, typically involving a struggle or dispute
Synonyms: Conflict, skirmish, quarrel
Antonyms: Harmony, peace
Example: The politician joined the fray to defend his position on the policy.

VOCABULARY

5. Incisive (तेज, गहरा)

Meaning: Having a sharp intellect or keen insight; clear and direct.
Synonyms: Penetrating, acute, sharp
Antonyms: Vague, dull, ambiguous
Example: Her incisive analysis of the problem helped the team find an effective solution.

6. Permeate (फैलाना)

Meaning: To spread throughout something; to pass through or penetrate.
Synonyms: Pervade, saturate, infiltrate
Antonyms: Contain, restrict, block
Example: The aroma of freshly baked bread permeated the entire house.

VOCABULARY

7. Untenable (अस्थिर, असमर्थनीय)

Meaning: Not capable of being defended or justified.
Synonyms: Indefensible, unsustainable, weak
Antonyms: Defensible, justifiable, tenable
Example: The scientist’s theory became untenable after new evidence disproved it.

8. Plausible (संभाव्य)

Meaning: Seeming reasonable or probable; capable of being believed or accepted.
Synonyms: Believable, credible, reasonable, likely
Antonyms: Implausible, unbelievable, improbable, unrealistic
Example: The detective presented a plausible explanation for the missing evidence, convincing the jury of the suspect's innocence.

VOCABULARY

9. Vituperate (डांटना)

Meaning: To criticize or insult someone in a harsh or abusive way.
Synonyms: Berate, scold, revile
Antonyms: Praise, compliment, commend
Example: The manager vituperated the employee for repeated mistakes, but it only demoralized the team.

10. Derisive (उपहासपूर्ण)

Meaning: Expressing contempt or ridicule.
Synonyms: Mocking, scornful, contemptuous
Antonyms: Respectful, admiring, flattering
Example: The audience gave a derisive laugh when the actor forgot his lines.

VOCABULARY

Phrasal Verbs:

1. Border on
Meaning: To be very close to or nearly something (e.g., an emotion, condition, or state).

2. Chew over
Meaning: To think about something carefully or discuss it thoroughly.

3. Fall behind
Meaning: To fail to keep up with others or a set schedule.

4. Freak out
Meaning: To become very anxious, upset, or excited.

VOCABULARY

Idioms & Phrases

1. Whale of a time

Meaning: to have a great time or to enjoy yourself very much

2. A mile a minute

Meaning: very quickly

3. Have a foot in the door

Meaning: have or gain a first introduction to a profession or organization

VOCABULARY

4. No time to lose

Meaning: there is no time to waste

5. Head in the clouds

Meaning: having unrealistic or impractical ideas

Article for Reading

Further south: on the Iron Age and the south

The Iron Age in India has been a subject of fascination and discussion. In the rest of the world, the Iron Age succeeded the Copper-Bronze Age or bridged the gap between the Bronze Age and the Early Historic period. But the situation in India is different: when the region north of the Vindhyas belonged to the pre-iron Chalcolithic or Copper Age, the south, with over 3,000 sites, was associated with iron. Many archaeologists have, generally and conservatively, placed the Iron Age to be in the second millennium BCE. Given this backdrop, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin's recent statement, that the origin of iron in the State could be traced to the first quarter of the fourth millennium BCE, is significant as this pushes the antiquity of iron further. After excavations in the mid-Ganga Valley of Uttar Pradesh about 25 years ago, early evidence of iron technology was dated to 1800 BCE.

But now, the work in Sivagalai in Tamil Nadu, which was carried out between 2019 and 2022, has made authorities attribute the introduction of iron in the country to the early part of the fourth millennium BCE, even though the period of 2500 BCE-3000 BCE is taken as a mid-range value. This forms the highlight of a study by the State Department of Archaeology (TNSDA), titled "Antiquity of Iron: Recent radiometric dates from Tamil Nadu". The TNSDA had the scientific dating results of its study validated by renowned institutions such as the Beta Analytic laboratory in the U.S. Mr. Stalin's observation was made keeping the findings in mind. Early this month, he announced a $1-million prize scheme for deciphering the script of the Indus Valley Civilisation. The work by the TNSDA should spur new thinking with regard to the strategies to be adopted by archaeologists who are working on the Iron Age of India. They may have to look for more iron-specific sites than copper-cum-iron sites, which will save time, energy and resources.

Even though the Tamil Nadu government supports research projects on a wide range of themes in other States, the TNSDA has its constraints with regard to territorial jurisdiction. This underscores the need for complementing Tamil Nadu's efforts with those of other southern States. The Archaeological Survey of India should take the initiative of bringing the entire southern region under a common fold and enabling well-designed and coordinated work. After all, the idea is to share available resources and expertise in the country to arrive at more reliable findings. At a time when certain forces are increasingly using history and culture as powerful instruments to pursue their political agenda, credible and concrete evidence on the antiquity of the country will naturally put to rest any claim based on baseless assumptions.

Summary

The Iron Age in India has been redefined by recent discoveries in Tamil Nadu, suggesting that iron technology in the region dates back to the early part of the fourth millennium BCE, significantly earlier than previously believed. Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin's remarks, based on radiometric dating results validated by international institutions, challenge earlier timelines of Indian iron usage, traditionally dated to 1800 BCE in the mid-Ganga Valley. This breakthrough, detailed in a study by the Tamil Nadu State Department of Archaeology (TNSDA), calls for a shift in archaeological focus toward iron-specific sites in southern India. Collaboration between Tamil Nadu, other southern states, and the Archaeological Survey of India is crucial to advancing research. The findings not only provide valuable insights into India's ancient history but also counter attempts to manipulate history for political purposes by relying on scientific evidence.

Tone:

The tone is informative and reflective, emphasizing the importance of recent discoveries, the need for collaborative research, and the broader implications of these findings for understanding India’s ancient history.

Reading Comprehension

Based on the above passage, answer the following questions:

Question 1

What role does the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) play, as suggested in the passage?

a) To validate findings from international laboratories.
b) To coordinate and unify research efforts across southern states.
c) To focus exclusively on the mid-Ganga Valley sites.
d) To limit research to sites within Tamil Nadu.
e) None of the above

Question 2:
What was the purpose of the Tamil Nadu government's collaboration with the Beta Analytic laboratory in the U.S.?

a) To validate the radiometric dating results of the TNSDA's study.
b) To analyze copper-cum-iron artifacts.
c) To establish Tamil Nadu as the earliest center of Iron Age technology globally.
d) To investigate the connection between the Indus Valley Civilisation and Tamil Nadu.
e) None of the above

Question 3:
What does the passage imply about the importance of credible evidence in historical studies?

a) It standardizes research methodologies globally.
b) It undermines the importance of territorial jurisdiction in archaeology.
c) It negates the need for international collaborations.
d) It helps counter politically motivated interpretations of history.
e) None of the above

Article for Skimming

Establishing the link between smartphone use and adolescents' mental health

A survey of over 10,000 adolescents (13-17 years) in the United States and India has revealed that mental well-being is closely linked with earlier age of initiation of mobile phones, and could decline significantly with each younger year of age. We reviewed 100 studies about little kids and screens. Sapien Labs' report titled 'The Youth Mind: Rising Aggression and Anger', documented the responses of 10,475 Internet-enabled adolescents across India and the United States in 2024. Although numerous factors have traditionally been identified as drivers of poor mental health, one key change in the younger generations is the arrival of smartphones, which were introduced in 2008, coinciding with the onset of rising mental health problems. The report highlighted key trends, with a particular focus on rising feelings of aggression, anger, irritability, and hallucinations in this age group.

The decline in mind health is characterised not only by sadness and anxiety but also by new symptoms, including unwanted thoughts and a sense of being detached from reality. Highlighting the differences between the American and Indian cohorts, Tara Thiagarajan, neuroscientist with Sapien Labs, said the pace of deterioration of mental well-being is slower in India. “While the overall decline in mental well-being in younger ages is strongly present for males and females in the U.S., it is only present for females in India and not in males (where only select aspects deteriorated, while others improved). Even for females, it (the overall decline in mental well-being) is not as steep in India,” Dr. Thiagarajan said. “On the other hand, both adolescent males and females in India have worse mental well-being on the whole, than their counterparts in the U.S.

While aggression, anger and hallucinations are consistently related to the age of smartphone initiation for both U.S. and Indian females, for girls in India, getting their phones very young is more likely to result in increased sleep and health problems as adults," she said. In an attempt to address this, there is a growing debate on the merits of educational technology (ed-tech) in the elementary and middle school years. "One of the possible solutions is also to provide restricted access to phones for teenagers using apps, which lock in parental controls regarding apps teens can access, while allowing them to access a school portal or messaging," Dr. Thiagarajan said.

Question 4:
What solution does Dr. Thiagarajan propose to mitigate the negative effects of smartphone use among adolescents?

a) Banning smartphones entirely for teenagers.
b) Limiting the availability of educational technology in schools.
c) Using apps that provide parental controls over smartphone access.
d) Encouraging early smartphone use under adult supervision.
e) None of the above

Question 5:
What distinction does the report make between mental well-being trends in the U.S. and India?

a) The decline is more severe for males in India than for females.
b) The decline in the U.S. is less steep compared to India for females.
c) Mental well-being in the U.S. is uniformly declining for both genders, whereas it is improving for both genders in India.
d) The mental well-being of males in India has improved in certain aspects despite overall deterioration.
e) None of the above

Today's Descriptive Question:

Original Text:

Ethanol Blended Petrol (EBP) is a fuel mixture comprising ethanol, a biofuel derived from renewable sources like sugarcane, maize, or other agricultural produce, blended with conventional petrol. This blend is gaining global attention as a sustainable alternative to reduce dependency on fossil fuels, cut greenhouse gas emissions, and enhance energy security. Most commonly, ethanol is blended with petrol in proportions ranging from 5% (E5) to 20% (E20), with some countries experimenting with higher blends like E85 for specialized vehicles. The advantages of ethanol blended petrol are multifold. As a renewable resource, ethanol contributes to reducing carbon emissions, as it burns cleaner than pure petrol. Its use can also provide a

significant boost to the agricultural sector, offering farmers additional revenue streams by utilizing surplus crops or agricultural residues. Furthermore, blending ethanol reduces the import of crude oil, saving valuable foreign exchange and supporting energy independence. However, there are challenges associated with ethanol blended petrol. Ethanol is hydrophilic, meaning it absorbs moisture, which can lead to engine corrosion or fuel system issues in vehicles not designed for higher ethanol blends. Additionally, large-scale ethanol production may lead to food security concerns if arable land is diverted from food crops to biofuel production. The transportation and storage of ethanol require specialized infrastructure, adding to initial costs. Governments worldwide are promoting ethanol blending programs to mitigate these challenges, with policies that incentivize production, ensure vehicle compatibility, and balance food and fuel priorities. Ethanol blended petrol thus represents a crucial step toward sustainable energy solutions.

Precis

Ethanol Blended Petrol (EBP), a mix of ethanol and petrol, is a renewable fuel alternative aimed at reducing fossil fuel dependency, lowering carbon emissions, and enhancing energy security. It benefits the environment, supports agriculture, and reduces crude oil imports.A

Despite advantages, challenges like engine compatibility, moisture absorption, food security concerns, and infrastructure requirements persist. Governments are addressing these issues through incentives, policies, and technological advancements, making EBP a key element in sustainable energy strategies.

- **You had scheduled a meeting with the manager of a reputed company. Due to unforeseen circumstances, you need to cancel the appointment. Write an email to inform the manager about the cancellation and request to reschedule at a convenient time.**

To: …….@gmail.com

Subject: Request to Reschedule Our Meeting

Dear [Manager's Name],

I hope this message finds you well. I am writing to inform you that, unfortunately, due to unforeseen circumstances, I will not be able to attend our scheduled meeting on [original date and time]. I sincerely apologize for any inconvenience this may cause and greatly appreciate your understanding.

I highly value the opportunity to connect with you and discuss [specific purpose of the meeting, e.g., "our potential collaboration" or "the ongoing project"]. I would be grateful if we could reschedule our meeting at a time that is convenient for you.

Please let me know your availability, and I will do my best to accommodate your schedule.
Thank you for your patience and flexibility. I look forward to your response.
Warm regards,
[Your Full Name]
[Your Position]
[Your Contact Information]

Match the column

1. Whale of a time	A. there is no time to waste
2. A mile a minute	B. have or gain a first introduction to a profession
3. Have a foot in the door	C. having unrealistic or impractical ideas
4. No time to lose	D. to have a great time or to enjoy yourself
5. Head in the clouds	E. very quickly

Answer:

1-d

2-e

3-b

4-a

5-c

Vocabulary

1. Antiquity:
2. Deciphering:
3. Derail:
4. Fray:
5. Incisive:
6. Permeate:
7. Untenable:
8. Plausible:
9. Vituperate:
10. Derisive:

RC ANS

1.

Ans: b

Explanation:

The passage emphasizes that the ASI should take the initiative to unify efforts across southern states to share resources and expertise for reliable findings.

Why Other Options Are Incorrect:

a) Validation by international labs is already part of TNSDA's process.

c) The focus extends beyond the mid-Ganga Valley to include southern India.

d) Tamil Nadu's jurisdictional constraints are highlighted, necessitating ASI's involvement.

2.

Ans: a

Explanation:

The passage mentions that the Beta Analytic laboratory validated the radiometric dating results of the TNSDA study, lending credibility to the findings.

Why Other Options Are Incorrect:

b) The focus is on iron-specific sites, not copper-cum-iron artifacts.

c) The study pertains to India, not global comparisons.

d) The Indus Valley connection is not the study’s focus.

3.

Ans: d

Explanation:

The passage points out that credible and concrete evidence is crucial to counter baseless claims that may arise from political agendas.

Why Other Options Are Incorrect:

a) Global standardization is not the focus of the discussion.

b) Territorial jurisdiction is highlighted as a limitation, not negated.

c) The study values international collaboration, as seen with Beta Analytic.

4.

Ans: c

Explanation:

Dr. Thiagarajan suggests apps that lock in parental controls, allowing restricted access to certain apps and portals while ensuring responsible smartphone use.

Why Other Options Are Incorrect:

a) She does not advocate banning smartphones entirely.

b) The debate on ed-tech is mentioned, but not as her proposed solution.

d) Early smartphone use is associated with negative outcomes, not encouragement.

5.

Ans: d

Explanation:

The passage highlights that the decline in mental well-being is present for both genders in the U.S., whereas in India, the decline is not observed for males overall; certain aspects of their mental well-being have improved.

Why Other Options Are Incorrect:

a) The decline for males in India is not more severe.
b) The U.S. shows a steeper decline in females' well-being, not India.
c) There is no indication of uniform improvement for both genders in India.

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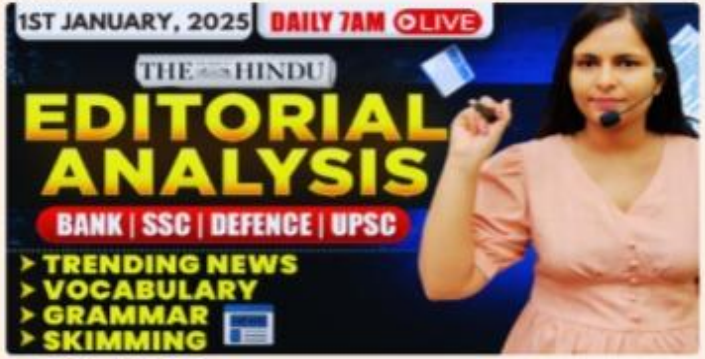

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